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JULIUS BAHNSEN, PHILOSOPHER OF HEROIC DESPAIR, 1830–1881

THE fate of Julius Bahnsen is a strange paradox in philosophic history. Although one of the most original and interesting thinkers in modern philosophy, he was condemned to spend his maturest years as a schoolteacher in the hindmost part of Pomerania, almost unknown, and even today he is not much more than a name, thought of (if at all) in connection with the history of nineteenth-century pessimism.

Three factors are involved in the estimation of his personality and philosophy and in the reasons for his isolation.

Philosophy was to Bahnsen not merely a system of intellectual convictions, construed by analytical abstraction and concerned with logical consistency. Philosophy was to him rather an attitude of faith, practical ethics, bound up with man's elemental emotions and having direct life-significance. His own philosophic orientation was determined throughout by the deepest and most intimate sources of his being. The high moral pathos of his argument, the rhythmic intensity and the individual character of his idiom, are striking indications of the significant extent to which his entire personality entered into his work. Ideas possessed personal values for him. However, the passion with which he fought for his persuasions involved him in constant controversies, carried on in a brilliant, yet extremely polemical manner. Everywhere he takes the position of a fighter, now assailing with fast rapier-thrusts, now defending with passionate counter-attacks, always disputatious. Indeed, the entire form of his presentation received its stamp from the controversies carried on against von Hartmann, Volkelt and others. His heated and militant tone has irritated many critics and has doubtless been a strong factor contributing toward the inadequate consideration that his system has received.

Another difficulty was offered by an unusual style. Bahnsen possessed a rich and bizarre imagination, and it found expression in a literary form colored with a kaleidoscope of similes and meta-

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phors. With the exception of George Santayana, we know of no thinker who clothes his ideas in so many figures of speech. His philosophic idiom consists for the most part of strong, sparkling epithets and of striking and involved analogies. Problems are anthropomorphized, appear arrayed in armor and fitted with spears; intense metaphors serve to keep the emotional tension high throughout a vivid and colorful fray. So that (as sometimes in the case of Santayana) unless one knows, to begin with, what the argument is about, one may be left wondering what specific point is under discussion. There are two further difficulties with Bahnsen's style. He employs a great many Latinisms and his sentences are very long and involved. No sooner is an idea introduced than it is qualified by another (sometimes placed in parenthesis), the latter in turn by some other and so on. One sentence often contains a wealth of deep and original reflections, but the problem is not infrequently lost in a welter of parenthetical digressions.

Finally there is the unique character of Bahnsen's philosophy. His *Realdialektik* assails the law of contradiction and the principle of the excluded middle, claiming that reality is throughout contradictory. It is an attack on long-established logical principles issued to an age nurtured on Hegelian panlogism. The strong temptation has generally been to dismiss this challenge without close examination, as a logical monstrosity. Equally antipathetic were the ethical consequences of this logic. Combining the contradictory aspects of Hegel's dialectic with the pessimistic elements of Schopenhauer's voluntarism, Bahnsen's system represents the first thoroughgoing pessimism in the history of thought. If Schopenhauer, von Hartmann, Mainländer and other pessimists ultimately offered 'solutions' in one form or another, Bahnsen teaches, practically, the inevitability of suffering throughout time and, theoretically, the impossibility of a logical grasp of nature. The difficulties that beset the infiltration of pessimistic philosophies had been powerful enough to prevent Schopenhauer's recognition for almost forty years. And Bahnsen wrote at a time when Hartmann's pessimism, which called for an active enjoyment of life and left the far-off future to trouble itself with the annihilation of the world, had gained wide popularity.

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I

Before proceeding to the exposition of the *Realdialektik,* something ought to be told about the ironic fortune that pursued Julius Bahnsen in his life.[1]

The intellectual milieu in which he awoke to critical selfconsciousness was dominated by the stimulating currents of the forties. This period witnessed the germination and ripening of the forces that attacked and temporarily dismembered orthodoxy in its metaphysical Hegelian garb as well as in its reactionary political form. The decade saw the appearance of the HALLISCHE JAHRBÜCHER, the organ of the Hegelian left wing, and of Feuerbach's *Essence of Christianity,* a colorful plea for a humanistic religion. This was also the time when Marx and Engels issued their pungent political manifesto. The period was permeated by a spirit of scepticism in theology, and of antagonism toward the pale abstractions of the Hegelians, and by a challenging attitude directed against the current conservative doctrines of the political economists. These were the turbulent waters that played about the young Bahnsen. They suited his critical-sceptical temperament and he was glad to swim in them. At first he was strongly gripped by the revolutionary political waves of the forties. But an inherently strong individualism soon led him to translate the acrid criticism levelled by the social radicals against the exploitations of a particular economic class into a fiery individualistic protest against the suppressive and choking attitude of a general bourgeois psychology. Personal mishaps and his academic failures produced in Bahnsen the feeling that he was a "marked man", an outcast, the natural enemy of the compact majority and its "moderate discretions". He struggled hard (and of course in vain) to reveal the insincere tactics he met with in the academic life, to pierce through the quiet intrigues and smooth hypocrisies of those discreet "gentlemen and scholars" who smile affably while they strike, and simulate a well-disposed attitude while they destroy. He had an unusual sense for unequivocal sincerity. And though

[1] Compare the sympathetic introduction of Rudolf Louis in his edition of Bahnsen's posthumous autobiography *Wie ich Wurde Was ich Ward* (München and Leipzig, 1905), quoted here as *Autobiographie.* The autobiography has been reedited by A. Ruest and reprinted by A. Barth, Leipzig, in connection with the celebration of the centenary of Bahnsen's birth, two years ago.

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he was continually subjected to social and economic ostracism from a milieu in which such transparent honesty was regarded as "not well taken", he was not discouraged. "And if my friends refused to listen to me, then the walls had to hear me or the stones in the fields and the trees of the forests."

Julius Bahnsen was born on March 30, 1830, in Tondern Schleswig, into a family of Frisian and Old-Saxon ancestry. His mother died shortly after giving birth and left the boy to a lonesome and saddened childhood. When he grew up, he was sent to the Gymnasium, and there he first came into contact with the prevailing critical currents. The year 1847 he designated as the time of his awakening to independent thinking. The idea that man is only "a selfconscious nothing" then suggested itself to him.[2] In the fall of 1848 he entered the university of Kiel, but the war of 1848–50, which involved Schleswig, interrupted his studies. He enlisted and served for eighteen months.[3] The following two years (1851–53) he spent at the university of Tübingen. He had originally intended to enter the theologic profession, but the reading of Feuerbach and Ruge and early leanings toward an antitheologic nihilism had soon led him to abandon this project, and instead he made philosophy his main study at Tübingen. Here Vischer, the renowned philosopher and lecturer on æsthetics, exerted the greatest personal influence upon him; but it was Reiff who introduced him to the general problems of philosophy, and it was through him that Bahnsen first heard of Schopenhauer.[4]

During his four semesters at Tübingen, Bahnsen did *not* attend any of the lectures of I. H. Fichte—although he was the dean under whom Bahnsen was to take the degree—for the reason that he felt repulsed by Fichte's theistically-colored idealism. Time

[2] From his reading in Trendelenburg during his university studies he remembered but one piquant sentence: there are negative minds whose thought-apparatus always tends toward negative conclusions. Bahnsen adds that from early youth on he listened with a receptive ear to everything which served critical dissolution. *Autobiographie*, p. 106.

[3] It is interesting to note that the three leading Schopenhauerian pessimists, Hartmann, Mainländer, and Bahnsen, voluntarily enlisted in the army and all for the same reason: to discipline and strengthen body and spirit—in behalf of the battle for Nirvana!

[4] Reiff's *System der Willensbestimmungen* presented a voluntaristic metaphysics without pessimistic implications.

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and again, such intellectual honesty, such disregard for 'diplomacy', became the source of academic setbacks. He himself chose the subject for his dissertation, which was "an attempt to analyze genetically, according to the presuppositions of scientific psychology, the doctrines with regard to the basic æsthetic categories".[5] Vischer's comment on it was that although the work fails to ground the idea of the beautiful on a new principle, it discloses, on the other hand, a wealth of deep and fruitful insights and an astonishing maturity of thought for a man of twenty-three.

All through his life Bahnsen regarded himself as a disciple of Schopenhauer. In the year 1856, he called on the master. "I went away conscious that I had seen not only a genius of ideas, but also a character of the most genuine sublimity . . . I felt myself . . . transported into a new existence. Francis of Assisi and the other heroes of asceticism had become my ideals."[6] Fourteen months later he saw Schopenhauer again. In the meantime he had read and studied "every line" of the revered teacher, and Schopenhauer now honored his new follower by ranking him with the "apostle" Frauenstädt.

Bahnsen's autobiography contains a heading, On a lost watch ("Auf verlorenem Posten"), and begins: "The longer I live, the more I feel that the simplest formula for the constancy of my fate is: On a lost watch". He goes on to tell how in life and in thought he seemed constantly misplaced. When in the fifties materialism came into vogue, he had long ago passed it; and when in the sixties Schopenhauer became the fashion, Hartmann's diplomatic pessimism deprived him of deserved recognition. The age which was acclaiming pessimism would know nothing of one who represented it clearly and intransigently. This condition was partly responsible for his failure to obtain a university chair; and, despite all efforts, he was compelled to spend his best years teaching elementary subject-matter in a small provincial town. A creative, original and dynamic personality was thus forced to expend his exuberant enthusiasm, his astounding energy and vitality, in the petty bickerings of provincial politics and in disciplining hardheaded Pomeranian youngsters.

[5] The work seems to be lost.

[6] *Autobiographie*, p. 47.

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Added to this, Bahnsen suffered in his private life from loneliness and from an ill-considered marriage. It was one of his deepest yearnings to establish a peaceful and harmonious household. This wish was not to be fulfilled. He was first married to a congenial and intelligent woman, but death took her from him only one year after their union. A second marriage proved in every respect a sad disappointment. On December 7, 1881, Julius Bahnsen died, only 51 years old, of what at first seemed a light case of diphtheria. He summarized his life in a self-chosen epitaph: *Vita mea irritus labor.*

II

The leading idea of Bahnsen's system, the key to his metaphysics, ethics, and æsthetics, is the principle of *'Realdialektik'*.[7] Its fundamental thesis states that the principle of contradiction is a predicate of existence, where existence comprises both the field of knowledge and that of nature. The term *'Realdialektik'* is employed in conscious opposition to Hegel's 'verbal' dialectic. *"Dialektik"* here signifies contradiction barring the possibility of a reconciling 'synthesis'. 'Real' indicates that this dialectic or contradiction has direct and full applicability to nature or reality. Hegel's conciliatory dialectic, Bahnsen claims, is only verbal. It can have no relevance to an existence the essence of which is not harmonious but antithetical. Kant distinguished between logical contradictions and existential oppositions, and showed that they may exist side by side; he also regarded antinomies as due to the specific nature of our *thinking* and as not being true of objects. The daring and startling claims of the *Realdialektik* are that contradictions embrace both the phenomenology of the spirit and that of nature, and that each individual element harbors opposing properties *within itself;* in other words, that everything in nature is permeated with antinomies, is split and divided against itself.[8]

Although all of Bahnsen's writings are more or less concerned with clarifying this idea, there is nowhere a rigorous proof offered. He points out the difficulty in the attempt at a logical exposition

[7] The most detailed exposition of this concept is found in Bahnsen's main work, *Der Widerspruch im Wissen und Wesen der Welt, Princip und Einzelbewährung der Realdialektik,* 2 Bde., Leipzig, 1882. Here quoted as *Realdialektik.*

[8] *Realdialektik,* Vol. I, pp. 62, 155; Vol. II, pp. 452 ff.

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and justification of an anti-logical principle. Moreover, the source of the *Realdialektik* is the insight that the nature of the world offers a riddle that we must despair of solving by means of logical categories. And Bahnsen calls on our intuitive faculties to bridge the gap between the world of the will and the world of knowledge. But though irrefutable reasons may be lacking, we may yet be convinced by undeniable facts.[9] Unfortunately, the illustrative facts adduced are few, scattered, and not always relevant. Moreover, he does not clearly distinguish between logical contradictions, metaphysical antinomies and existential oppositions; and though his term '*Realdialektik*' is supposed to include them all, the illustrations offered apply primarily to the last only.

The realdialectic phenomenon which Bahnsen stresses most of all is that of selfconsciousness. Its simplest form already discloses the union of opposites, a subject and an object. While the ego wills, it is at the same time the product of willing; it continually undergoes development and yet always retains its identity; it wills and it knows; it flees from the grasp of thought and yet is alone capable of awareness. What was for Schopenhauer a 'miracle' (that the self is both subject and object) the *Realdialektik* calls the most fundamental antinomy of life. Throughout Bahnsen's writings we find references to other realdialectic phenomena in various fields, ranging from epistemology and physics to psychology and metaphysics. In epistemology we have the paradoxical situation that an object, *to be known,* has to be beyond the knowledge-sphere and yet it must at the same time be in it. The play of physical forces is based on the law of action and reaction, and reveals that no force can exist unless it be resisted by some other force. Further examples of inseparable physical oppositions are the phenomena of polarity, of centripetal and centrifugal gravity, and of ebb and flow. Biological life and growth are conditioned by the constant dying and shedding of tissues. All genuine ethics combines self-assertion and self-negation. We are reminded of the legal dictum: *summa jus, summa injuria.* The possibility of progress presupposes the inadequacy of a particular existing situation. Bahnsen points to the psychological fact that our brain functions momentarily better in periods of mental exhaustion and

[9] *Realdialektik,* Vol. I, pp. 8, 97, 26, 45.

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calls attention to the proverbial desire for knowledge, a desire which increases with every acquisition of knowledge. Metaphysically, we are faced by similar complementary diremptions. The more we insist on change and difference, the more we imply a certain actual persistence and identity. Causality (as Kant has shown) rests on a united opposition: the cause must contain the effect and yet be different from it. Similarly, the world contains both chance and necessity, matter and mind, law and contingency, etc.[10]

The basis for the contradictory nature of all existence Bahnsen places in the Will. The thesis that a blind will makes for the irrationality of existence had already been maintained by Schopenhauer. But his introduction of the Platonic Ideas and the power he bestowed on the intellect brought some order and reason into a wilful regime. Bahnsen's will, on the other hand, is and remains uncompromisingly irrational, admitting no logical monitor to interfere with its activities. The whole realm of existence is the exclusive manifestation of its capriciousness. Now the will too is subject to the universal principle of *Realdialektik,* and this means that it is also ontologically split and self-divided. Thus at no stage does the will appear as a single or unified entity; its "self-division is *a parte ante* and *a parte post* equally eternal". In other words, contradictions inhere in the pure will, before and aside from its self-contradictory content. A contradictory dialectic is thereby placed into the heart of the cosmic process. Bahnsen regards this dialectic as a characteristic of both the world of existence and the world of essence, as the "absolute inner content of being". If Hartmann weds his empty and yearning will to the idea, thereby endowing the will with a logical content, Bahnsen, barring such liaison and insisting on the will's supreme independence, points to the motivating element of its own nature as the will's only and proper content. Lacking thus any logical entrails, the will expresses its realdialectic idiosyncrasy (already made familiar by Schopenhauer) in that it finds peace only through the unrest of a striving that continues eternally in spite of all failures.[11] The will

[10] *Zur Philosophie der Geschichte,* Berlin, 1872, pp. 27, 43. Hereafter quoted as *Philosophiegeschichte. Realdialektik,* Vol. I, pp. 37, 50, 93, 113; Vol. II, pp. 7 ff., 20, 59, 62, 65, 82, 84, 194, 464 ff., and *passim.*

[11] *Realdialektik,* Vol. I, pp. 46, 51, 245, 291; *Philosophiegeschichte,* p. 2.

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wants (rest) what it does not want (to will). Cursed with dissension, it constantly tears at itself by forever reaching out from every here and now to some distant there and then.

The metaphysical collision between the realdialectic jaws of the will, by which the objective world of reality is constituted, also appears in the psychological conflicts between divergent desires and motives within the same organic individual appearance.[12] There arises the problem of the relation of the universal will and its particular manifestations. Throughout, Bahnsen inveighs against any form of pantheism and stoutly defends an individualistic pluralism. He rejects Schopenhauer's epistemology and holds that space, time and causality, change and becoming and hence individual existence, are not alone real, but are the sole reality. Only if we consider time and space real can we explain willing (a temporal process) and the existence of plurality. *Individual* wills alone exist (Bahnsen calls them *Henaden,* or ultimate will-atoms). They have eternal ontological status and, in consonance with their realdialectic nature, are forever at war with one another. But while he holds to the substantiality of individual wills, Bahnsen (true to his principle of polarity) at the same time speaks of a universal will. The relation between the two he does not make clear. Sometimes he seems to regard the *Henaden,* at other times the will, as the primary reality. That is, he swerves between a pluralism and a monism.[13]

III

This metaphysics appears to imply a sweeping and unmitigated pessimism. A world whose essence is a blind and split will, which manifests itself in irrational self-tearing individuals, having an eternal ontological subsistence, leaves no opening for a ray of reason, contains no moment of respite, offers no avenue of escape and no possibility of salvation. To begin with, we have all the dreary aspects of Schopenhauer's "worst of worlds". Due to the

[12] Gottfried von Strassburg's Tristan is cited as experiencing in his breast such tearing self-discord:

> Wider sînem willen kriegete er,
> er gerte wider sîner ger,
> er wolte dar und wolte dan.

[13] *Realdialektik,* Vol. II, pp. 70, 80, 102 ff., 169, 429, 446.

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will, there is the same curse of restless activity and desire without possible repose and satisfaction, the same struggle and eternal denial to our cherished yearnings. But Bahnsen's pessimism goes further yet. Schopenhauer's will, though blind, acts in part as if it were intelligent. It appears in a number of ordered objectifications and in the last event produces an intelligent offspring. Bahnsen's world knows no such power that might revolt against the erratic reign of the will and bring peace to the suffering subjects. Here the irrational ruler is and remains unrivalled. Moreover, owing to its realdialectic character the will desires both to will and not to will, and this inseparable opposition of its nature prevents it from radically and effectively denying or affirming itself. "The conclusion of the *Realdialektik* is: 'It does not suffice' either for complete annihilation or for full satisfaction. The child of Gäa is born between heaven and hell, now ready to camp with the lightshunning creatures of the Chthonic darkness, now ready to flutter upwards to the heights of splendor." It is this standing between two worlds, this hovering and swinging between two extremes and never reaching an equilibrium, that makes for man's eternal disharmony. Bahnsen translates Plato's metaphysical utterance, that we are as much as we are not, into ethics. We 'participate' sufficiently in the realm of values to have a great yearning for it, and this realm is metaphysically so far removed from us that our longings remain forever unappeased. The sphere of values and the sphere of existence are necessarily distinct, although they always imply and point to each other. The tragedy of man consists precisely in that his world is neither clearly monistic nor sharply dualistic. This double-edged formula seals a consistent pessimism. It denies the possibility of a whole-hearted affirmation or negation of the will to live, deprives man of the hope of finding happiness in an active life or peace in a Nirvana-state, forces him out into a disconsolate Ahasuerus-eternity. For the particular individual this dualism spells inevitable tragedy. For tragedy arises from the desire to do two things while being able to do only one.[14] Bahnsen's will knows no thesis and synthesis but

[14] Bahnsen quotes Rüdiger in the *Niebelungenlied* as expressing the "*Urwort*" of all tragedy:

> Swelhes ich nu lâze unt das ander begân,
> so hân ich boesliche un vil uebel getân:
> lâz aber ich sie beide, mich schendet elliu diet.

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only an antithesis, no 'idea' to plan a purposeful evolutionary process. It knows only an endless self-masochism and torture. ("In ewiger Selbstentzweiung zu endloser Qual an sich selber zerrend.")[15]

Among the powers attributed to man by the classical tradition in philosophy is the possibility of comprehending nature's processes by means of thought. If man fails in other (practical) pursuits, he can always gain peace and maintain his dignity through this intellectual vision. The *Realdialektik* challenges this claim as well.

Since the structure of existence is dialectic, the canons of formal logic cannot be adequate for a conceptual grasp of it.[16] Hegel's dialectic was a method for describing the development of the logical idea only, and not of empirical existence. Moreover, this metaphysics attempted a violent construction of reality by means of ghostly concepts, and, in the attempt to establish one and the same law for both being and thinking, it ignored the limitations of the former in its blind worship of a faultless panlogistic order. Actually, however, existence is characterized by contradictions, and since logical categories necessarily exclude such, logic is forever destined to failure in its attempt to express the nature of being. It follows further that thought stands in contradiction to itself. In its search for truth it must—if it is to formulate the nature of an antinomical reality—become untrue to its own law. The adjustment of logical thinking to anti-logical existence is impossible. In this way Bahnsen bars the temple which had hitherto been held open as the last refuge of "a free man's worship".[17]

A realdialectic metaphysics is necessarily pledged to a sceptical philosophy of history. In an early and special treatise Bahnsen marshals inductive and deductive arguments against the evolutionary and teleological optimism of Hegel and Hartmann.[18]

[15] *Das Tragische als Weltgesetz,* Lauenburg i. P., 1877, reprinted by A. Barth, Leipzig, 1930. *Realdialektik,* Vol. I, pp. 177, 211 f., 9; Vol. II, pp. 211 f., 359 f., 401, 328, 482, 236; *Pessimistenbrevier,* (anonymous), Berlin, 2 Aufl., 1881, p. 101 and *passim; Autobiographie,* pp. 174–5; *Philosophiegeschichte,* p. 14.

[16] The claim is not that the principle of *Realdialektik* applies to logic. The intactness of the logical relation *of concepts* to each other remains. *Cf. Realdialektik,* Vol. I, pp. 63 f., 203.

[17] *Realdialektik,* Vol. I, pp. 198, 13, 202–3.

[18] *Zur Philosophie der Geschichte, op. cit.*

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As we have seen, the sole reality in Bahnsen's world is a plurality of individual wills. But unlike the monads of Leibniz these *Henaden* are not windowless, and their preëstablished course is not one of harmony but of discord, for they are constantly and openly at war with one another as well as within themselves. This eternal inter- and intra-individual masochism is the sole subject-matter of a circular world-process, constitutes the only 'progress' there is. In striking and strong locutions Bahnsen assails panlogistic historicism and asks how Hegel's 'idea' or Hartmann's all-wise Unconscious can be reconciled with historical 'errors' such as the *caput mortuum* of old India and the extinction of races. "Shall we regard these as reservoirs of the world-spirit, which the latter uses as a temporary lodging, before entering his headquarters with all the troops?" And Bahnsen continues by pointing out the methodological advantage of his own principle. On the basis of its Janus-character the *Realdialektik* can explain *both* purpose and haphazardness in history. On the other hand, Hegel's panlogism, if strictly interpreted, offers "no asylum for lawless vagabonds (sinners against the logical order), no free playground granted by the master of the world in his good humor to each of these kobolds, where they might have the privilege of moving about and of enjoying themselves in a manner unrelated to the rational world-purpose—until their day also came and the broomstick of the court-master would sweep them out into the sanctum". Bahnsen's protest is against a forceful reading of plan and logic into historical events. The path of history is not marked out by logical categories but stained with bloodclots drawn by the realdialectic sword. History, too, in spite of Hegel and Marx, cannot get beyond the antithesis. The grave of every world-period is the certain berth of a new sepulchre.[19]

Bahnsen's pessimism embraces existence and knowledge, the world and the individual. The axis of the world is pain and it is turned by the inexhaustible energy issuing from the dark 'Mothers' of the underworld.[20] His eschatology offers no escape from the tortures inflicted on us by others and by ourselves. Neither can suicide liberate us, for after death the individual be-

[19] *Geschichtsphilosophie*, pp. 38, 45, 70 ff., 84.

[20] *Das Tragische als Weltgesetz*, *op. cit.*, pp. 52 f.

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comes what it was before: an invisible act of the will, which requires but the occasion of a new impulse to become visible again. Life is thus a painful *perpetuum mobile*. Through the whole world stalks a never-ending discord, for the will carries the roots of dissatisfaction in its breast through all eternity. Theoretically, too, the way is barred; for all our knowledge turns about in a circle of contradictions. And to the spinozist's consolation that peace may be gained by a realization of the necessity of the world's process Bahnsen retorts passionately: "The inability to resign oneself to the necessary order, is also a necessity and the pain is on that account no less!" Bahnsen's pessimism seems absolute.[21]

IV

Curiously enough, however, the very principle of *Realdialektik*, by virtue of its insistence on the polar nature of all existence, pledges Bahnsen to admit the existence of some reason as well as of some values in the universe. He is aware of the logical consideration that the universe cannot be condemned as a whole, that the absence of an objective standard makes an absolute or universal pessimism impossible. To begin with, he makes the purely formal admission that a certain regularity does exist, namely the regularity of contradiction, in that the contradictory will retains its identity.[22] Furthermore, he realizes that what is altogether contradictory is meaningless or unthinkable, and he indicates that to some extent experience must be regarded as having order. He finds that *within* the split individual object *each half* pursues a logical course and that the only contradiction that exists is that between the two halves. It is this "partial logic" that explains the existing limited adaptability of thought to reality. He also grants that, in some instances, the dialectic of nature allows for some good to enter into an evil world.[23]

Bahnsen speaks of man's innate love of life. It makes itself felt even in the dreary consequences of the *Realdialektik*. At least

[21] *Realdialektik*, Vol. II, pp. 494, 425, 78.

[22] *Pessimisten-Brevier*, p. 247; *Philosophiegeschichte*, p. 67.

[23] *Realdialektik*, Vol. I, pp. 167–8, 194, 356, 151–2; Vol. II, pp. ii, ix, 84, 482; *Pessimistenbrevier*, pp. 247, 199. In the preface to the second volume of the *Realdialektik* Bahnsen professes only a scepticism with regard to finding logical categories adequate for a description of natural phenomena.

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in one instance Bahnsen points to a definite avenue of escape—namely, through humor. In humor the intellect for once is liberated from the sinister power of the will; and with a mighty effort it swings itself up into the sphere of the pure spirit—and laughs. It is not the laughter of Democritus born out of a glad acceptance of the inevitable, but the laughter of a realdialectic spirit standing on its own shoulders, observing the deep tragedy below, and for the moment free to observe it. Here Bahnsen, perhaps unintentionally, pays tribute to Hegel. The *Weltgeist* appears as the beacon-light, which in moments is able to pierce through the darkness of the will.

But it is more through the practical implications which Bahnsen draws from his philosophy that his pessimism loses something of its sting. Although he does not admit the possibility of a radical solution, he reminds us that man can still save his dignity by a heroic and stoic acceptance of the inescapable. "Ich denk' als Männer tragen wir auch dies. . . ." He condemns as futile all the escapes which Schopenhauer proposed, and turns in particular against the romantic idealists who persist in sighing and yearning for objects that lie beyond their grasp. This only leads to a futile sentimentality and to an enervating *Weltschmerz*. And in contrast to all previous pessimisms (except the lusty brand offered by Hartmann), the *Realdialektik* urges the abandonment of quietism. Man finds things not as he would like them to be, and although he is in no position to alter the situation, he has nevertheless a desire to do something about it. Herein lies the practical and realdialectic justification of an active life. "What in all the world", Bahnsen calls out, "has courage to do with hope?"[24] Emphatically affirming the will to live—to be sure, not with Nietzsche's Dionysian joy in existence, but because he believes the denial of the will to be an impossibility—Bahnsen the 'dysangelist' is found at the end of his road battling for the same flag that the life-drunken chanter of the superman has sworn by, but with the difference that Bahnsen is fighting for a flag that he knows is doomed to eternal defeat.

Although Bahnsen regarded himself as a follower of Schopen-

[24] Bahnsen's discussion of humor is found in *Das Tragische als Weltgesetz, op. cit.; Realdialektik,* Vol. I, pp. 211, 3; *Autobiographie,* p. 180.

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hauer, actually (as we have already indicated) few Schopenhauerian planks appear in the *Realdialektik*. A transcendental realism with regard to time, space and causality and a pluralism replace Schopenhauer's subjectivism in epistemology and his pantheism. The teleological objectifications of Schopenhauer's will, the Platonic Ideas, and finally the solutions through art, contemplation, love and asceticism, which blunted the edge of Schopenhauer's pessimism, are all rejected by Bahnsen.[25]

Even looser bonds exist between Bahnsen and Eduard von Hartmann. To be sure, both thinkers attempted an amalgamation of Schopenhauer's and Hegel's philosophies; however, Bahnsen accepts in both what Hartmann rejects (Schopenhauer's irrationalism and Hegel's dialectic of "negativity") and rejects in both what Hartmann accepts (the logical elements).[26]

It thus becomes clear that Bahnsen represents the direct antipode to Hegel. The *Realdialektik* opposes Hegel's verbal dialectic. Panlogism is replaced by a double legislature for being and thought. For Hegel the illogical and the principle of contradiction are only transitional moments from the logical (thesis) to the logical (synthesis). For Bahnsen the logical serves only as a transitional moment from the alogical to the illogical.[27] Finally Bahnsen eschews Hegel's evolutionism, pantheism and optimism.

Both the manner and matter of Bahnsen's philosophy invite

[25] *Realdialektik*, Vol. II, pp. 105, 169, 429 and *passim*. Bahnsen is at one with Schopenhauer in affirming the primacy of the will and in regarding the intellect only as its efflorescence. He also holds to Schopenhauer's idea that character is immutable and that man is determined in *operari* but free in *esse*. *Cf. Realdialektik*, Vol. II, "Moirologischer Anhang". The struggle for existence in nature was for Schopenhauer also a revelation of the will's "self-dissension" ("Entzweiung mit sich selber"). *Cf. Welt als Wille und Vorstellung*, 3 Aufl., Vol. I, p. 175.

[26] Bahnsen and Hartmann, diametrically opposed in character and temperament as well, stood at one time on friendly footing with each other. Further personal contact, however, (at Driburg in 1872 and 1873) brought about differences rather than agreements. That Hartmann's dexterity and virtuosity in presenting ideas (mostly of others) should be evaluated highly, while his own original insights should be ignored, was a source of bitterness to the older man. *Cf.* R. Louis in *Autobiographie*.

[27] Originally, Bahnsen holds, the metaphysical *Ens* had nothing to do with reason, was alogical. But since man has acquired "the norm of a logical scheme (as a secondary product of the will)", the alogical had to appear, when measured in its terms, as antilogical. *Cf. Realdialektik*, Vol. I, p. 203.

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criticism. But in what terms can such critique be stated? It is the aim of the realdialectic principle to reveal the impotence of logical method. Bahnsen himself takes recourse to analogy and metaphor, calling on his reader to use his imagination and to trust his intuition. And suppose it could be logically demonstrated that inconsistencies exist in Bahnsen's system? The *Realdialektik* might very well welcome such proof as an illustration of its very principle; it would be (as said) acting in the spirit of the *Realdialektik* to challenge its contentions. And if space permitted, the attempt might be made to elaborate the following difficulties, which can here only be stated. How reconcile the substantiality of the *Henaden* with that of the universal will? How account for the origin and development of consciousness and of a "partial logic" in a world ruled from the beginning by an alogical will? The *Realdialektik,* as was pointed out before, fails to draw clear distinctions between contradictions, antinomies, and oppositions, and neglects to show the respective fields each applies to. With regard to contradictions it may be said that they can exist only in the domain of formal logic and that it is meaningless to speak of things or objects as such being contradictory. The challenge seems, however, not to be directed against the principle of contradiction but primarily against the applicability of the principle of the excluded middle to existence. Bahnsen's more persistent claim is that the nature of actual existence is polar, that objects and events conflict with one another and (since they possess opposed properties) also with themselves, and that existence therefore eludes being grasped by formal logic. He raises here an important logical question which we cannot go into at this point. But it should be noted that even though this contention be granted it does not pledge one to his pessimism. For in spite of the Schopenhauerian attempt to show a bond between irrationalism and pessimism, it may be questioned whether happiness is necessarily conditioned by logical knowing. And though it may be true that every event in the universe is conditioned by a force opposing it, the fact remains that actions, movements and the like ('progress' in a certain sense) exist. Though we may not be getting anywhere, some satisfaction may yet be derived from the effort itself.

Nevertheless, however valid the criticisms that have been levelled

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against Bahnsen may be, one should beware of following in Hartmann's steps and dismissing him on the sole ground that his system lacks consistency. How many systems in the history of philosophy are generally regarded as altogether consistent or 'tenable'? The classical philosophers are held in high esteem, not because we have accepted and swallowed their entire systems, but mainly because of their partial insights and stimulating suggestions. Seen in this light, the very demerits of Bahnsen's philosophy become virtues.

In the *Realdialektik* we possess a work of profound aperçus, of fearless and trenchant criticism, and a thought-provoking discussion of ultimate issues. Philosophy also owes to Bahnsen the most forceful statement of the irremovable objective antinomy of life: the necessary opposition between value and existence or the value-dualism of reality. And the point that the universe contains both matter and mind, necessity and freedom, law and chance, may prove to be an Ariadne-thread through the labyrinths of metaphysical discussion and strife of systems. And those who suspect in the widespread Hegel-renaissance of today an attempt to cloud economic and intellectual issues by a concealed theology will find that their presumptions have been anticipated to some extent by Julius Bahnsen, next to Karl Marx the most clearcut anti-Hegelian of the nineteenth century.

With the exception of Johannes Volkelt, no academic thinker has ever made a serious attempt to do justice to Julius Bahnsen, the most original of Schopenhauer's followers. It is time that academic philosophy opened its doors to a highly interesting system, even though its arguments may not be close and logic-knit throughout, especially since the leading ideas of two noted contemporary philosophers touch on the problem fundamental to his thought.[28]

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[28] The reference is to Nicolai Hartmann's doctrine of *Aporien* (*Cf.* his *Grundzüge einer Metaphysik der Erkenntnis*) and to Morris R. Cohen's principle of polarity (*Cf. Reason and Nature,* New York, 1931).

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